



THE BRAND-FUNDED DOCUMENTARY SYSTEM

START HERE

How to Use the Brand-Funded Documentary System

Practical funding strategy for independent and documentary filmmakers

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Welcome to **The Brand-Funded Documentary System**.

You bought this because the old way of funding documentaries got harder, and you'd rather learn how the money actually moves than wait for it to come back. Good instinct. Let's get to work.

This module is short on purpose. It tells you three things: what this system is, how to use it, and what we promise you (and what we don't). Read it once before you start Module 1. It will save you time later.

What this system is

This is a step-by-step method for getting documentaries funded by brands, companies that will pay to be associated with your film in exchange for specific, negotiated deliverables. Not grants. Not streamers. Not your uncle. Brands.

The method has a name: **the Sponsor-Fit Method**. It runs across seven modules, in order:

- 1 **The 2026 Funding Map:** where the money went.
- 2 **Positioning:** what a brand is actually buying when it funds a film.
- 3 **The 25-Brand Target List:** how to build a real list of companies to approach.
- 4 **The 12-Slide Sponsor Deck:** the proposal that speaks the brand's language.
- 5 **Outreach:** the four-email cadence for people who hate selling.
- 6 **The Call, the Menu, the Number:** how to run the conversation and price the deal.
- 7 **Paper:** how to keep both the money and the film.

Each module builds on the one before it. Module 3 needs your Module 2 worksheet. Module 6 needs your Module 4 deck. Don't skip. If you jump to "how do I price it" before you've done positioning, you'll price the wrong thing.

How to use it

Read one module, then do the exercise before the next. Every module ends with an action checklist. Those checklists are the actual product. The reading is context; the doing is the work. A filmmaker who reads all seven modules in one sitting and does nothing has spent \$297 on a PDF. A filmmaker who does one checklist a week for seven weeks has a funded-shaped pipeline for current and future projects.

Keep one document open the whole time. Call it your Sponsor-Fit Workbook. Every exercise output goes there: your one-line audience answer, your Four Assets worksheet, your 25-brand list, your deck, your email drafts. By Module 7 that document is your campaign. You'll reuse it for every film after this one.

Use the templates. This system ships with templates, the 12-slide deck structure, the four emails, the deliverables menu, the valuation worksheet, the deal-memo skeleton. They're referenced by letter (C through G) inside the modules. Don't rewrite them from scratch. Customize them to your film. That's the point, and the value of these modules.

Watch for the example thread. Throughout these modules you'll follow one fictional filmmaker, she's making a documentary about rural nurses, as she works each step. She is not a real client. Nothing about her is a promise about what will happen to you. She exists so you can see the method applied to a specific film instead of in the abstract. When you see her, read it as "here's what the step looks like," not "here's what worked for someone."

Watch for the story slots. In a few places you'll see notes marked `[KERRY STORY: ...]`. Those are where Kerry David, the seasoned filmmaker behind this system, 25 years of funding films, \$90M at the box office, 75 Film Festival Awards for her projects, drops a first-person account from the field. They're placed where a real war story teaches more than instruction can.

The honest promise

We're going to be plain and direct with you, because these are the foundations of our brand and company.

We teach you the mechanics. We do not guarantee funding.

Here is what that means, specifically:

- **No earnings claims.** We will not tell you what you'll make. We don't know your film, your market, your work ethic, your timing, or how well you'll run the plays. Anyone who quotes you a number they haven't earned on your behalf is selling you something else.
- **No funding guarantees.** Running this system well improves your odds of a productive brand conversation. It does not promise a signed deal. Some films fit brand money beautifully. Some don't, and part of this system is helping you tell which is which early, before you waste six months.
- **No invented success stories.** You will not find "one filmmaker raised \$X" claims in here, because we don't manufacture results. The one filmmaker you'll meet is clearly fictional, used only to illustrate the steps. Kerry's stories are from the trenches and have been practiced and proven.

What we *do* stand behind: the frameworks are real, drawn from 25 years of funding films the older way and the years of funding them, which includes this way. The templates work. The numbers in the pricing modules are honest ranges from the indie-doc market, not fantasy. The volume math is realistic, it tells you to expect a handful of replies from 25 targets, not a flood, because that's the truth and it's still enough. You set your brain against rejection. Kerry's mantra at this point is, "Great, I'm one no nearer to my yes."

The reframe that makes all of this work is in Module 1: a grant funder asks, *"is this film worthy?"* A brand asks *"is this film useful to us, will it expand our reach, grow our sales or confirm customer loyalty?"* Worthiness is judged. Usefulness is negotiated. You have far more control in the second conversation. This whole system is about becoming an expert in that conversation.

One more thing, because it comes up in every module and it's non-negotiable: **sponsors buy association and access, never final cut.** Your subjects' trust and your editorial

independence are not for sale. They're also, not coincidentally, the thing that makes your film worth sponsoring in the first place. We'll protect both in writing by Module 7.

Before you start

Open a blank document. Title it with your film's name plus "Sponsor-Fit Workbook."
Then turn to Module 1.

That's it. See you there.

A note on scope: this system covers the funding method. It is not legal or tax advice. Where a deal needs a lawyer, or an accountant, and Module 7 tells you exactly when, get a lawyer and an accountant. We'll tell you what to hand them. All serious filmmakers who are choosing this profession as a career needs a great attorney and accountant. Ask filmmaker friends who they use and take lots of meetings before deciding.